

Cryptanalyzing a bit-level image encryption algorithm based on chaotic maps

Heping Wen^{a,b,*}

^a*School of Electronic and Information Engineering, University of Electronic Science and Technology of China, Zhongshan Institute, Zhongshan 528402, China*

^b*School of Information and Communication Engineering, University of Electronic Science and Technology of China, Chengdu 611731, China*

Abstract

Recently, a bit-level image encryption algorithm based on chaotic maps was proposed [1], in which a diffusion-permutation structure with only one round is adopted. In this paper, we performed a comprehensive cryptanalysis on the BCIEA. Theoretical analysis and experimental simulations verify that BCIEA cannot resist a chosen ciphertext attack method.

Keywords: image encryption, cryptanalysis, bit-level, chaos.

1. Introduction

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 reviews the cryptosystem proposed in [2]. Then, Sec. ?? presents a comprehensive cryptanalysis on BCIEA. Section ?? verifies the effectiveness of the attack method. The last section concludes the paper.

2. The cryptosystem under study

This section first presents the basic principle of bitplane decomposition, and then introduces BCIEA briefly.

2.1. Bitplane decomposition and composition

2.2. Description of BCIEA

The block diagram of BCIEA is shown in Fig. . As can be seen, the main components of BCIEA are introduced briefly as follows:

- *The chaotic map and the Secret Key:*

In BCIEA, a chaotic map is used twice to generate several keystreams for encryption. The piece-wise linear chaotic map (PWLCM) is mathematically modeled by

$$x_i = F(x_{i-1}, \eta) = \begin{cases} x_{i-1}/\eta, & 0 < x_{i-1} < \eta \\ (x_{i-1} - \eta)/(0.5 - \eta), & \eta \leq x_{i-1} < 0.5 \\ F(1 - x_{i-1}, \eta), & 0.5 \leq x_{i-1} < 1 \end{cases} \quad (1)$$

where x is the state variable, $x_0 \in (0, 1)$ is the initial value and $\eta \in (0, 0.5)$ is the control parameter, respectively. In BCIEA, two different groups of initial values and control parameters (x_0, η_1, y_0, η_2) are served as the secret keys.

- *Initialization:* For the sake of generality, the encrypted object is an 8-bit grayscale image of size P of size $M \times N$ (height $\times$ width). The initialization operation consists of two parts: one is converting the plain image into its bit-level form, and the other is generating the keystreams by the chaotic map for the first time.

*Corresponding author.

Email address: hepingwen2016@gmail.com (Heping Wen)

- By BBD, convert the plain image P of size $M \times N$ (height $\times$ width) into two 1D sequences A_1 and A_2 of length $4MN$. For convenience, let L be $4MN$.
- With the initial parameter η_1 and the initial value x_0 , get a sequence X_1 by iterating Eq. (1) for $N_0 + MN$ times and discard the former N_0 values, given as

$$X_1(i) = \text{mod}(\text{floor}(x(i)) \times 10^{14}, 256)$$

where $i = 1 \sim MN$, floor is the function that takes an integer, and $X_1(i) \in \mathbb{Z}_{256}$. Then, two sequences b_1, b_2 of length L are obtained from X_1 by the method of binary bitplane decomposition. Here, $b_1, b_2 \in \mathbb{Z}_2$.

• *Stage 1. diffusion:*

Step 1. Firstly calculate the sum of A_2 , represented as

$$\text{sum}_1 = \sum_{i=1}^L A_2(i) \quad (2)$$

where $L = 4MN$. Then run a cyclic right shift operation on A_1 with sum_1 bits to obtain A_{11} .

Step 2. Get B_1 by performing the bitwise XOR operations between A_{11} , A_2 and b_1 , given as

$$\begin{cases} B_1(1) = A_{11}(1) \oplus A_{11}(L) \oplus A_2(1) \oplus b_1(1) \\ B_1(i) = A_{11}(i) \oplus A_{11}(i-1) \oplus A_2(i) \oplus b_1(i) \end{cases} \quad (3)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$.

Step 3. Like Step 1, firstly compute the sum values sum_2 of B_1 as

$$\text{sum}_2 = \sum_{i=1}^L B_1(i) \quad (4)$$

Then, get A_{22} cyclic right shifting A_2 with sum_2 bits.

Step 4. Similar to Step 2, obtain B_2 from A_{22} , B_1 and b_2 , modeled by

$$\begin{cases} B_2(1) = A_{22}(1) \oplus A_{22}(L) \oplus B_1(1) \oplus b_2(1) \\ B_2(i) = A_{22}(i) \oplus A_{22}(i-1) \oplus B_1(i) \oplus b_2(i) \end{cases} \quad (5)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$.

• *Stage 2. Confusion:*

Step 1. Firstly compute the sum values of B_1 and B_2 by

$$\text{sum} = \sum_{i=1}^L (B_1(i) + B_2(i)) \quad (6)$$

Further update the initial value of the chaotic map by

$$s_0 = \text{mod}(y_0 + \text{sum}/L, 1) \quad (7)$$

Then, with the initial parameter η_2 and the initial value s_0 , using Eq. (1) again, generate a chaotic sequences of length $2L$, and then process it into two integer sequences Y and Z both of length L . Here, $Y, Z \in [1, L]$.

Step 2. Use Y and Z as coordinate indexes, and then get C_1 and C_2 by confusing the positions of the elements in B_2 and B_1 respectively. Exactly, given as

$$\begin{cases} C_1(i) = B_2(Y(i)) \\ C_2(i) = B_1(Z(i)) \end{cases} \quad (8)$$

where $i = 1 \sim L$.

Finally, get the cipher image C from C_1 and C_2 by the method of BPC.

As stated in [1], the decryption process is the inverse of the encryption process, but the specific steps are not described. For more details, please refer to [1].

3. On the decryption of BCIEA

3.1. Problems with the decryption

As everyone knows, ensuring the decryption is available is a basic condition for good cryptosystems. In addition, decryption is an integral part of cryptanalysis. For this reason, we discuss the decryption part firstly.

- *Initialization:* As with encryption, two initialization operations are performed:

- Get C_1 and C_2 from the cipher image C by BPD.
- Generate the keystreams b_1, b_2 by the secret keys (η_1, x_0) .

- *Stage 1. Anti-confusion:*

Step 1. Firstly compute the sum values of C_1 and C_2 by

$$sum = \sum_{i=1}^L (C_1(i) + C_2(i)) \quad (9)$$

Note that the sum of B_1 and B_2 is equal to the sum of C_1 and C_2 because the confusion only changes the positions of the elements. Then, with the same secret keys (η_2, y_0) , update the initial value y_0 to s_0 and further obtain the two coordinate indexes sequences Y and Z .

Step 2. Restore B_1 and B_2 from C_2 and C_1 by the anti-confuse, given by

$$\begin{cases} B_1(Z(i)) = C_2(i) \\ B_2(Y(i)) = C_1(i) \end{cases} \quad (10)$$

where $i = 1 \sim L$.

- *Stage 2. Anti-diffusion:*

Step 1. Corresponding to Step 4 of the confusion, recover A_{22} from B_2 , B_1 and b_2 , modeled by

$$\begin{cases} A_{22}(1) \oplus A_{22}(L) = B_2(1) \oplus B_1(1) \oplus b_2(1) \\ A_{22}(i) \oplus A_{22}(i-1) = B_2(i) \oplus B_1(i) \oplus b_2(i) \end{cases} \quad (11)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$.

Step 2. Obtain sum_2 by Eq. (4), and then get A_2 by doing cyclic left shift operation on A_{22} with sum_2 bits.

Step 3. Recover A_{11} by performing the bitwise XOR operations between B_1 , A_2 and b_1 , given as

$$\begin{cases} A_{11}(1) \oplus A_{11}(L) = B_1(1) \oplus A_2(1) \oplus b_1(1) \\ A_{11}(i) \oplus A_{11}(i-1) = B_1(i) \oplus A_2(i) \oplus b_1(i) \end{cases} \quad (12)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$.

Step 4. Obtain sum_1 by Eq. (2), and then get A_1 by doing cyclic left shift operation on A_{11} with sum_1 bits.

Finally, get the plain image A from A_1 and A_2 by the method of BPC.

Observing Eqs. (11) and (12), the decryption results are the bitwise XOR values of two elements, instead of the values of an element. In fact, this paradigm will lead to solutions that are not unique. To this end, the following proof is given from the perspective of algebraic analysis.

Take Eq. (11) as an example, let $x(i) = A_{22}(i)$, $\alpha(i) = B_2(i) \oplus B_1(i) \oplus b_2(i)$. Thus, Eq. (11) becomes

$$\begin{cases} x(1) \oplus x(L) = \alpha(1) \\ x(i) \oplus x(i-1) = \alpha(i) \end{cases} \quad (13)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$, $x, \alpha \in \mathbb{Z}_2$. Here, α is known, and x is to be determined. One can conclude that x has two solutions regardless of the value of α due to the symmetry of two unknowns in this equation.

For example, when $L = 4$ and $\alpha = "1010"$ is known. Then, both $x = "1100"$ and $x = "0011"$ are solutions of Eq. (13).

Obviously, this violates the condition that the encryption and decryption functions required by the cryptosystem are single shot.

3.2. A slight correction on the decryption

To ensure correct decryption, and refer to other similar algorithm designs [3], a reasonable correction is to replace $A_{11}(L), A_{22}(L)$ with $A_{11}(0), A_{22}(0)$ respectively, and $A_{11}(0), A_{22}(0) \in \mathbb{Z}_2$ also act as secret keys. Thus, without changing the idea of the algorithm, the equations of encryption are corrected to:

$$B_1(i) = A_{11}(i) \oplus A_{11}(i-1) \oplus A_2(i) \oplus b_1(i) \quad (14)$$

and

$$B_2(i) = A_{22}(i) \oplus A_{22}(i-1) \oplus B_1(i) \oplus b_2(i) \quad (15)$$

where $i = 1 \sim L$. Accordingly, the equations of decryption Eqs. (11) and (12) become

$$A_{22}(i) = A_{22}(i-1) \oplus B_2(i) \oplus B_1(i) \oplus b_2(i) \quad (16)$$

and

$$A_{11}(i) = A_{11}(i-1) \oplus B_1(i) \oplus A_2(i) \oplus b_1(i) \quad (17)$$

where $i = 1 \sim L$. This ensures the correctness of the decryption.

4. Cryptanalysis

For the adversary, the goal is to restore the acquired cipher images to the original plain images. A common way is to get its real or equivalent key. In BCIEA, the secret keys are $(x_0, \eta_1, y_0, \eta_2, A_{11}(0), A_{22}(0))$ considering the correction for the decryption given in Sec. 3.2. In fact, the difficulty of finding $(x_0, \eta_1, y_0, \eta_2)$ is quite large, even impossible, because the preproces operation as shown in Equation 1 is used. To do this, we turn our goal to get their equivalent keys, exactly $(b_1, b_2, A_{11}(0), A_{22}(0))$ for the diffusion and (Y, Z) for the confusion respectively.

4.1. Analysis on the diffusion part

The generation process of the two diffusion sequences b_1, b_2 are independent of the plain images. Also, $A_{11}(0)$ and $A_{22}(0)$ are not related to plain images. Thus, $(b_1, b_2, A_{11}(0), A_{22}(0))$ can be considered as a permanent equivalent key of the diffusion under a given secret key.

Based on chosen ciphertext attack, one can choose the all-zero cipher image $C^{(0)}$ and get its corresponding plain image $A^{(0)}$. Then, one gets $B_1^{(0)} = 0$ and $B_2^{(0)} = 0$ because the confusion does not change the element value. Also, $A_1^{(0)}$ and $A_2^{(0)}$ are also known according to the basic assumption of the cipher is public. At this point, the original algorithm is actually a diffusion-only process. Eq. (16) becomes

$$\begin{aligned} A_{22}^{(0)}(1) &= A_{22}(0) \oplus B_2^{(0)}(1) \oplus B_1^{(0)}(1) \oplus b_2(1) \\ &= A_{22}(0) \oplus b_2(1) \end{aligned} \quad (18)$$

$$\begin{aligned} A_{22}^{(0)}(i) &= A_{22}^{(0)}(i-1) \oplus B_2^{(0)}(i) \oplus B_1^{(0)}(i) \oplus b_2(i) \\ &= A_{22}^{(0)}(i-1) \oplus b_2(i) \end{aligned} \quad (19)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$. Here, one has $sum_2 = 0$ because $B_1^{(0)} = 0$. Thus, $A_2^{(0)} = A_{22}^{(0)}$. Moreover, $A_{22}(0)$ is fixed for a given key. Let $\hat{b}_2(1) = A_{22}(0) \oplus b_2(1)$, Eq. (18) evolves to

$$\hat{b}_2(1) = A_{22}(0) \oplus b_2(1) = A_{22}^{(0)}(1)$$

And Eq. (19) evolves to

$$b_2(i) = A_{22}^{(0)}(i) \oplus A_{22}^{(0)}(i-1)$$

where $i = 2 \sim L$. Thus, one can determine the result of $A_{22}(0) \oplus b_2(1)$, namely $\hat{b}_2(1)$, and $b_2(i)$ for $i = 2 \sim L$. Note that $A_{22}(0)$ and $b_2(1)$ always appear in pairs, so there is no need to ask for specific $A_{22}(0)$ and $b_2(1)$.

Secondly, one gets $A_{11}^{(0)}$ from $A_1^{(0)}$ by doing cyclic right shift with sum_1 bits. Here, sum_1 associated with $A_2^{(0)}$ and $A_1^{(0)}$ are both known, thus $A_{11}^{(0)}$ is determined. Further, similarly following Eq. (17), Let $\hat{b}_1(1) = A_{11}(0) \oplus b_1(1)$, one has

$$\hat{b}_1(1) = A_{11}^{(0)}(1) \oplus A_2^{(0)}(1)$$

When $i = 2 \sim L$, one has

$$b_1(i) = A_{11}^{(0)}(i) \oplus A_{11}^{(0)}(i-1)$$

Then, all the equivalent keys $(b_1, b_2, A_{11}(0), A_{22}(0))$ of the diffusion are solved.

4.2. Analysis on the confusion part

4.3. The proposed attack method

5. Conclusion

This paper performed a comprehensive cryptanalysis on a chaotic image encryption scheme based on a variant of Hill cipher so-called BCIEA. We found that BCIEA cannot resist a chosen plaintext attack because of its inherent security defects. Both theoretical analysis and experimental verification were provided to support that BCIEA can be broken with low computational and data complexity. This study can provide a reference for improving the security of image encryption technology.

Acknowledgement

References

- [1] L. Xu, Z. Li, J. Li, W. Hua, A novel bit-level image encryption algorithm based on chaotic maps, *Optics and Lasers in Engineering* 78 (2016) 17–25. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.optlaseng.2015.09.007>. URL <http://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0143816615002109>
- [2] Image encryption scheme based on a new secure variant of hill cipher and 1d chaotic maps, *Journal of Information Security and Applications* 47 (2019) 173–187. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jisa.2019.05.006>.
- [3] F. Özkaynak, Brief review on application of nonlinear dynamics in image encryption, *Nonlinear Dynamics* 92 (2) (2018) 305–313. doi:10.1007/s11071-018-4056-x.